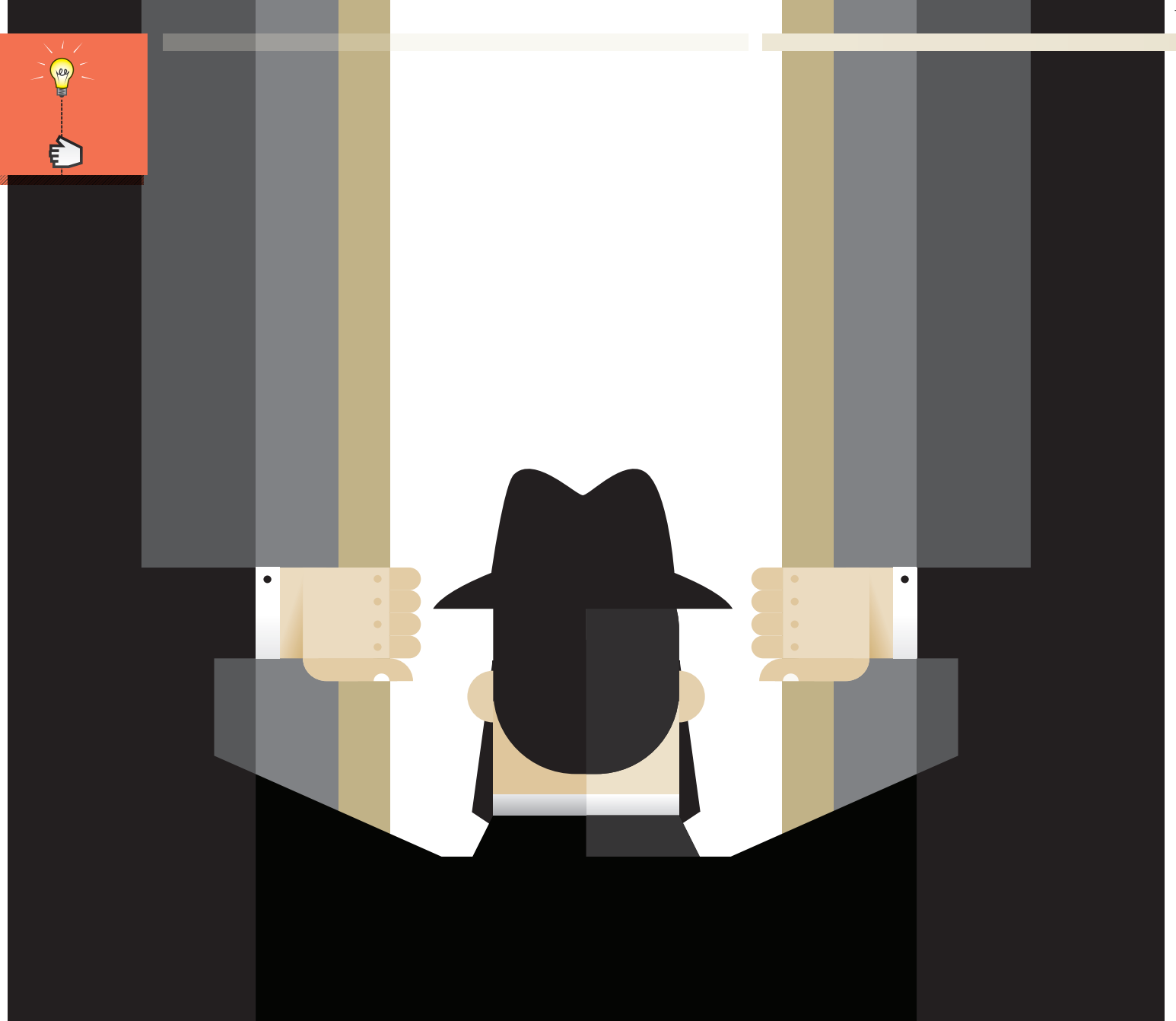




On Fulfilling the Ultimate Shlichus

HOW TO MAKE MOSHIACH A
REALITY TO OUR BAALEI BATIM

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From the many challenges that characterize our shlichus, the most crucial is perhaps also the most difficult. How can we make our baalei batim see geulah and Moshiach as a reality? How can the Rebbe's vision become our vision and their vision?

This is the one area defined by the Rebbe as the primary avodas hashlichus of today: to educate, inspire, and motivate whoever we can with the message of geulah and Moshiach.¹

This is the core of our shlichus—because it is the tachlis of all the mitzvot and all our peulos. Indeed, it is the ultimate purpose of Creation.

In light of its importance, it is obvious that we need to focus all our efforts and seek out every possible strategy so that no obstacle will stand in our way.

Understanding the Impediments

One of these obstacles, says Rabbi Dovid Katz, shliach to the West Hampstead neighborhood of London, is that it does not entail doing something concrete. “Let’s say I want to make a shtetle about mitzvot tefillin. I’ll bring down a sofer to demonstrate how tefillin are made and the work that goes into writing the parshiyos, and I’ll offer discounts toward checking tefillin and purchasing new pairs. When it comes to Moshiach, you’re starting off with a topic that is elusive and seemingly abstract.”

Additionally, there is the concern that the discussion will turn to uncomfortable topics, such as Christian connotations (see sidebar on page 59), among others.

However, we cannot solve these issues by avoiding them. To put it frankly, “doing nothing doesn’t work,” says Rabbi Tzvi Freeman of Chabad.org.

We cannot adopt the view that as shluchim of the Rebbe, we can do our part by strengthening Yiddishkeit, preventing intermarriage, and providing material and spiritual assistance, and leave it at that. These may comprise the bulk of our shlichus, but “we must not forget that the geulah is the tachlis of brias ha’olam and of Torah and mitzvot,” says Rabbi Levi Jacobson of the Jewish Russian Community Center of Ontario. “For someone who has learned the Rebbe’s Torah, it is inconceivable for this not to be his driving force and underlying spirit.”

Neither can we claim that the concept of Moshiach is too lofty and beyond the grasp of our baalei batim. As the Rebbe says (see sidebar), since this is the shlichus of the nossi of our generation, it can surely be conveyed to each

Is Moshiach Too Lofty for Them?

In this sichah, the Rebbe focuses on the importance of motivating children to ask for Moshiach. However, as the Rebbe remarked on many occasions, “children” can have a dual meaning—in age and in knowledge. The Rebbe’s words thus certainly apply to spreading an awareness of Moshiach among the members of our community.

—Rabbi Levi Jacobson

בשעת מפרעגט ביי אים א שאלה, ווי קומט דאס צו אראפלאזן אזא ענין נעלה ווי משיח צו קינדער - ווערט ער אינגאנצן צוטומלט!
לכל לראש - דארף ער וויסן אז דער ענין איז אמת!
לכל לראש - דארף ער וויסן אז דאס איז אמת לאמיתתו!
לכל לראש - דארף ער וויסן אז וויבאלד דאס איז א שליחות פון נשיא דורנו - האט דאס א שייכות צו די קינדער פון דעם דור!
און אויב נאר ער וועט ניט גלייך צוטומלט ווערן, נאר ער וועט זיך אין דערויף אריינבראכטן, וועט ער זעהן אז אזוי האט געפסק'נט דער רמב"ם, און נאך פאר אים - שלמה, וואס דעמולט איז געווען א נתינת מקום לשאלה צי דער "חונך לנער" דארף זיין "ע"פ דרכו", אדער באופן אחר - און מהאט אפגעפסקנט אז עס דארף זיין "ע"פ דרכו", ובמילא דארף ער מסביר זיין דעם ענין פון משיח צו אלע קינדער, צו אמעריקאנער, צו פראנצויזישע, און צו ענגלישע, און רעדן צו יעדען אין זיין אופן. און אויב ער טוט ניט אזוי - איז ער מועל אין דער שליחות אויפן ענין החינוך!

(שיחות קודש תשמ"א ח"ב ע' 409-408)

8 See also *ibid.* pp. 400-402.

and every one of *today's* Yidden. As one of the thirteen ikrei emunah, it is crucial to impart this to our community, and it is up to us to find the correct way to express it to them.

In the maamar *Ve'atah Tetzaveh 5741*,² the Rebbe demands that we must feel utterly disturbed and “shaken up” from the fact that Moshiach is not yet here. When we need to influence a baal habos to make a donation, we’ll put in all our efforts and do whatever it takes. When we experience something in our personal lives that touches our core, we’ll move mountains to make things happen. Similarly, Moshiach must be something that is *noge’a be’etzem*. It is not just another beautiful part of Yiddishkeit; it must stir us up until we *ker a velt*, not letting anything deter us from making Moshiach a reality.

1 Sichah of *Shabbos Parshas Chayei Sarah*, 5752 (*Sefer Hasichos* 5752, Vol. 1, p. 97).

2 *Sefer Hamaamrim Melukat*, Adar-Sivan, pp. 39-40.



ho'amitis vehashleimah. Seeing how someone truly *kochs* in Moshiach and speaks about it with conviction has an automatic effect on the viewer."

CONSTANT PREOCCUPATION

When a person is absorbed with a certain idea, he'll associate it with everything he does. He'll eat it, drink it, sleep it, dream about it, and breathe it. Whatever topic is brought up, he'll inevitably find a way to connect it with his obsession.

The Rebbe explains (see sidebar) that nowadays, since we are standing at the threshold of the geulah, "we are engrossed in achakeh lo bechol yom sheyovo," and this surfaces in whatever comes our way. If we are preoccupied with the geulah and Moshiach, we will connect it to every peulah and

Living With It

First and foremost, says Rabbi Katz, Moshiach must be something real in our lives. "There's no way you can give over this idea to baalei batim if you're not fully engrossed in it yourself."

Take, for example, the idea of keeping Shabbos. "Our mekuravim know that this is something real to us. If someone makes a degrading remark about our 'radical' attentiveness to keeping Shabbos, we'll find a way to answer and shed a positive light on it. They see that it matters to us to be a frum Jew, and this affects them."

Rabbi Jacobson agrees. "When Moshiach is real for us, we can make it real for our baalei batim," he emphasizes. "Think about how the Rebbe did it for us. He spoke about Moshiach constantly and connected it to each date and concept. I think it is safe to say that the majority of maamorim and sichos end with a tefillah for the geulah

mention it at every shiur or event, says Rabbi Katz.

Artificial remarks that stick out like a sore thumb will not do the trick. Moshiach must be real to us, and then talking about it will be a natural outcome.

"When a person is absorbed with a certain idea, he'll eat it, sleep it, breathe it."

INTERNALIZING THE REBBE'S PERSPECTIVE

How can we make Moshiach real for ourselves? One answer is to do the research. Chassidus explains from a myriad of angles how everything we do is a stepping stone toward achieving the ultimate goal of dirah betachtonim. The more we learn Chassidus

and the Rebbe's sichos, the more Moshiach will become an actual part of our mindset.

In addition to study, Rabbis Jacobson and Katz recommend hearing sichos or watching videos of the Rebbe talking about Moshiach. "Hearing the energy in the Rebbe's voice can truly fire

a person up and make Moshiach something tangible,” they say.

THE POWER OF SPEECH

Additionally, the mere act of mentioning and talking about Moshiach can help it become more real. Chassidus explains³ that speech has the ability to increase a person’s sechel or midos, making a concept better understood and more deeply felt. To quote the known adage, “האמנתי כי אדבר” — talking in and of itself can strengthen a person’s emunah.

“Don’t be embarrassed to discuss Moshiach,” adds Rabbi Katz. “The more you talk about it, the more it will become a natural topic, and the more it will be accepted by others.”

Finding the Right Words

Perhaps the greatest challenge in bringing the concepts of geulah and Moshiach to our baalei batim is finding the right words. How do we express these ideas in a way that resonates with them, so that they don’t sound abstract or off-putting?

THROUGH THE LENS OF CHASSIDUS

“The truth is that these ideas are far from abstract,” emphasizes Rabbi Moshe New of the Montreal Torah Center. “The key is to explain the geulah as part of the overall story of Jewish history, as the culmination of the purpose of Creation. Hashem created the world for us to transform it into a dirah lo yisborech through Torah and mitzvos. The geulah is the time when this goal will reach fruition.”

When these concepts are taught and spoken about time and again, the concept of geulah will fall into place on its own. “People are open to the idea that there is a Divine purpose to it all,” he says. “The geulah is then seen not as a foreign concept, but as an idea that cannot be otherwise.”

The Rebbe explains⁴ that, from a halachic perspective, the geulah is when we will be able to fulfill Torah and mitzvos in their ideal form. Indeed, a Yid must be bothered by the fact that only 87 mitzvos assei out of 248 can be performed today. However, to inspire the average mekurav to want Moshiach, we cannot just tell him that we will then be able to sacrifice sheep once more, without providing further background. Similarly, describing Moshiach as a time of world peace and otherworldly phenomena has limited effectiveness and can be viewed as some utopian dream.

“The most effective way to spread the message of geulah is through Chassidus,” says Rabbi Freeman. This is not a novel approach it is the solution given to the Baal Shem Tov by Moshiach himself!

“The key here is maayanos—pure, undiluted Chassidus

as we were taught in yeshiva,” he continues. “We must talk about avodas habirurim, dirah le’atzmus, and similar ideas.”

How are we to convey such profound topics? Chassidus provides us with meshalim people can relate to and that bring out the concepts beautifully. Presenting these ideas using familiar terminology and meshalim from everyday life allow them to be understood and absorbed by the common layman.

“Take for example the moshol of the world being Hashem’s garden,” suggests Rabbi Freeman. “Beyond the external mayhem lies an inner beauty. Each mitzvah we do unlocks this treasure, until we ultimately see the world for what it is—Hashem’s garden. Similarly, Chassidus describes golus as a pregnancy leading up to a birth. Moshiach is the time when the power hidden within our present accomplishments will be revealed and unleashed.”

The role of Moshiach as the one who will effect this geulah can be explained in a similar way as well. “Neshamos began as a single neshamah klalis, which then ‘broke down,’ as it were, into neshamos pratiyos. In the terminology of Chassidus, this is the yechidah klalis that includes every individual yechidah pratis,” explains Rabbi New. “Moshiach is thus not some

אהא! דאס איז מרמז אויף דער קץ הגאולה!

אין דעם אלעם קומט צו אן ענין הכי עיקרי. ובהקדים: בשעת א מענטש ליגט שטארק אין א געוויסע זאך, איז דער טבע בן אדם, אז בשעת עס קומען נאך זאכן זוכט ער און געפיגט - צום אלעם ערשטן - די נקודה משותפת מיט דער זאך אין וועלכער ער ליגט (אציפ וואס אין דעם קענען זיין נאך ענינים, און ענינים עיקריים).

בנוגע צו אידן, ובפרט בסוף זמן הגלות (לאחרי וואס כלו כל הקיצין, און כח מרח אדמיר האט מעיד געווען אז מהאט שוין תשובה געטאן און מהאט אלץ פארענדיקט) - **ליגט מען** אין “אחכה לו בכל יום שיבוא”, אז במשך כל היום (בכל יום) ווארט מען און מבענקט נאך דער גאולה האמיתית והשלמה.

און וויבאלד אז אידן קאכן זיך אין ביאת המשיח - איז פארשטאנדיק, אז אין יעדער זאך זוכט מען לכל לראש די שייכות מיט אחכה לו בכל יום שיבוא...

ועדו איז אויך מובן בנוגע צו דער פרשה וועלכע מלייענט דעם שבת חנוכה: גלייך בשעת א איד הערט און דערהערט בקריאת התורה דעם ווארט “מקץ” - כאפט ער זיך: אהא! דאס איז מרמז אויף דעם קץ הגלות, און קץ הימים און קץ הימין, דער קץ הגאולה!

(ספר השיחות תנש”א ח”א ע’ 204-203)

3 See *Yom Tov shel Rosh Hashanah* 5659.

4 *Likutei Sichos*, Vol. 18, Balak 2.



PRESENTING THE FACTS

Another important facet is, in the Rebbe's words, to "open our eyes." We must develop a deeper perspective of current developments, uncovering the external layers and viewing them with the Rebbe's *kuk*.⁵

"Opening our eyes doesn't mean to merely read the news," says Rabbi Freeman. "People can easily have a distorted picture of the facts. When we present raw data—be it the decline of poverty and war, breakthrough in technology, or advances in global communication—people will see for themselves how the world is accelerating toward a state of perfection."

Even negative themes, such as the rise of anti-Semitism in Europe, demonstrate the uniqueness of the present time. "Anti-Semitism is the flipside of our role as a light unto the nations," says Rabbi New. "It is not for naught that the world today is obsessed with Jews."

YIDDISHKEIT IS VIBRANT!

A big part of the way Moshiach is accepted by our baalei batim, says Rabbi Freeman, has to do with how we present Yiddishkeit, Torah and mitzvos. "If Judaism is all about respecting the traditions of our ancestors—"Jewish continuity," as it is very often presented—Moshiach doesn't fit into the picture.

"Yiddishkeit as we were taught is all

about changing the world, and every mitzvah is another step towards accomplishing that. When displayed in such a light, then Moshiach is a pervasive element, the tachlis of all we are doing."

FOCUSING ON CURRENT EVENTS

Connecting Moshiach to current events can also be an effective tool in conveying the concept to baalei batim.

"It can be hard to pique

their interest if you begin by talking directly about Moshiach," says Rabbi Uriel Vigler of the Chabad Israel Center of the

sublime individual, but the essence of each and every one of us. This idea underscores Jewish unity, a concept that resonates with people as well."

In this way, Moshiach differs, say, from mitzva tefillin. When approaching a Yid with tefillin, explaining the inner dimension of the mitzvah is secondary to the ikar—that he actually put on tefillin. With Moshiach, however, the Rebbe told us to *study* inyanei geulah u'Moshiach. The goal is to *educate* our communities and inspire them to live with this reality.

"There's no way you can give over this idea to baalei batim if you're not fully engrossed in it yourself."

⁵ See *Toras Menachem*, Vol. 42, pp. 267-268.

Upper East Side. “Even if they are interested, the ideas can appear foreign or abstract. When you somehow connect it to a hot topic, it becomes something to which they can relate.”

Rabbi Vigler points to his weekly *Two Minutes of Torah* video. During the heat of the Powerball frenzy, he aired a clip—which attracted a record number of views—showing him purchasing a lottery ticket in a local shop. “Focusing on the tagline ‘Hey, You Never Know,’ I conveyed the Rambam’s message that the entire world should be viewed as hanging in the balance. ‘Hey, you never know,’ I said. ‘Your action can be the one to bring Moshiach!’”

“Whenever I can, I connect the weekly post on my blog with Moshiach, often focusing on current events. For example, a recent post highlighted how we must ‘poll’ ourselves daily to see how we are bettering ourselves and boosting the campaign for our leader, Moshiach.”

ADDRESSING THE INDIVIDUAL

Another essential point is that Moshiach must be brought to each person in a style he can relate to and understand. “Each shliach deals with a unique group, in all types of communities with different mentalities,” says Rabbi Jacobson. “Each person must be approached in his own language.”

For example, the Rebbe advises⁶ that children should be told about the miraculous events of the geulah, such as the abundance of sweets. Since this is what is significant to them, it is the way to instill them with a desire for Moshiach.

Similarly, for more simple individuals, “the tangible dimension of the geulah can be emphasized,” says Rabbi New. “People accept the idea that it cannot be that humanity is destined to suffer. The Holocaust is not the final word on the Jewish nation. The concepts of justice and harmony resonate and express optimism and positivity.”

This approach can actually help us show others how they already desire Moshiach without even realizing it. Each person struggles with various issues and personal problems. When they are told that the underlying cause of all of humanity’s suffering is golus, and that when Moshiach will come all these problems will be absolved, a desire for Moshiach will automatically result.

“People will be inspired when they hear us speak with conviction and optimism,” concludes Rabbi New. “We must keep on looking for fresh, innovative ways to convey the message of geulah to the people with whom we come in contact.”

Care in Conveying the Rebbe’s Message

The following is an excerpt from *Samarkand: The Underground With a Far-Reaching Impact* (pp. 610-611, printed here with permission from the author), in which Rabbi Hillel Zaltzman describes the early peulos of Chamah in Eretz Yisroel in the 1970s.

At that time, I noticed a full-page ad in the newspaper *Yediot Acharonot* entitled “Know Your Judaism,” which made me think of a new way to reach Russian émigrés. I told R. Moshe [Nisselevitch], and we translated a recent talk of the Rebbe and published it as an ad in the popular Russian language weekly *Nasha Sterna*. We sent a copy of the paper to the Rebbe.

A week later, R. Efraim Wolf called us and said that the Rebbe had sent 600 liras to participate in the cost of the ad. We had never heard of the Rebbe transmitting money for specific activities or programs and we asked R. Wolf what it was about. He explained that it showed that the Rebbe had enjoyed seeing our recent work and was encouraging us with his monetary participation. Hearing this, we continued to publicize a talk of the Rebbe every week in Russian, sending a copy to the Rebbe every time.

Certain people came to us with complaints that our translation was imprecise. They were correct; we didn’t attempt to translate the talks word for word but endeavored instead to relay the Rebbe’s message accurately. I didn’t consider myself to be an expert in Russian, but I countered that a literal translation from the original Hebrew could sometimes have a Christian ring to it, G-d forbid, to the uneducated Russian reader. My rationale wasn’t well accepted, and our critics insisted on complete fidelity to the Rebbe’s original words.

Half a year later, Professor Yirmiyahu Branover related to me that in a past *yechidus*, the Rebbe had spoken critically of those who translate his talks in too literal a manner. “They think they are doing me a favor,” the Rebbe had told him, “but the opposite is true. The results sounds like something put out from the Church, G-d forbid! The translator must focus on the content and not on the exact wording, so that it does not sound improper.”

Of course, I was overjoyed to hear that I had come to the same view on the matter as the Rebbe.

⁶ *Sichos Kodesh* 5741, Vol. 2, pp. 403-405.



Practical Tips:

The following are some practical ideas shluchim have utilized and suggested:

1 INTEGRATE IT. There are many ways we can bring Moshiach into our interaction with baalei batim. Prepare a vort on the geulah that can be shared with people on the go. Integrate Moshiach concepts into drashos, classes, and discussions. Mention a vort on the geulah after minyanim and before or after meetings. Include a request for the geulah when reciting a prayer on behalf of an individual or the community. If you say a few words after each aliyah in shul, you can dedicate one of them to a thought on Moshiach. A very useful tool is the book *Moshiach Day by Day* (published by the Moshiach Campaign), that includes a vort on Moshiach and geulah for every day of the year.

—Rabbi Jacobson

2 UTILIZE SOCIAL MEDIA. When sending emails, include a link to sites dedicated to explaining Moshiach. Links or banners can also be incorporated in your local chabad

“Moshiach must be brought to each person in a style he can relate to and understand...”

website and social media page. If you come across an inspiring article on the topic, promote it on social media.

—Rabbi Jacobson

3 HIGHLIGHT WHAT THEY’RE FAMILIAR WITH ALREADY.

Davening is replete with requests for Moshiach (e.g., kaddish), as is our daily conduct. Go no further than netilas yadayim, which we *all* do so that the kohanim will be accustomed to eating terumah with purity when Moshiach comes!⁷ When we show people that they are already asking and preparing for Moshiach,

they will be more inclined to accept it.

Elaborating on the haftoros, especially of the shiva denechemta, can be an especially effective way to demonstrate Moshiach’s integral position in classical sources.

—Rabbi New

4 PACK THE PUNCH. To create a special emphasis on Moshiach, harness the element of ponim chadoshos and bring a guest speaker to discuss the topic with your community. For an even greater effect, join with neighboring shluchim and arrange a symposium dedicated to addressing various aspects of geulah and Moshiach.

—Rabbi Katz

5 FIND A TIME WHEN THEY’RE OPEN. People can sometimes be more receptive to Moshiach when they’re out of their “comfort zone.” Looking at the members of his community, Rabbi Katz says that the ones who are most inspired about Moshiach are those with whom he held discussions out of town, such as during skiing trips. Simchos can also be suitable occasions to mention the ultimate simcha of the geulah. Conversely, when visiting a mourner or officiating at a levayah, rachamana litzlan, you can recite a prayer for the geulah when we will be reunited with our loved ones.

6 GET STUBBORN. Join an “akshonim” group (see page 71 in this issue).

—Rabbi Jacobson

Written by Rabbi Yehuda Altein

⁷ See Alter Rebbe’s *Shulchan Aruch*, 158:1.